The New Nationalism

Theodore Roosevelt · Osawatomie, Kansas · August 31, 1910 · excerpts

Source: Theodore Roosevelt, 'The New Nationalism' (Osawatomie, Kansas, Aug. 31, 1910), text via Teaching American History. Public domain.

Two years out of office and growing restless under his successor Taft, Theodore Roosevelt gave this speech at the dedication of a John Brown memorial. It launched his progressive agenda — graduated income and inheritance taxes, federal regulation of corporations, and stronger executive power — and previewed his 1912 Bull Moose campaign. He framed strong federal action as the necessary modern equivalent of Hamiltonian nationalism.

> *Connect: TR's push for a strong federal government echoes Hamilton's original Federalist argument (Class 6). Trace one line from Hamilton to TR.*

Key Passages

The Square Deal

I stand for the square deal. But when I say that I am for the square deal, I mean not merely that I stand for fair play under the present rules of the game, but that I stand for having those rules changed so as to work for a more substantial equality of opportunity and of reward for equally good service.

On labor reforms

We keep countless men from being good citizens by the conditions of life by which we surround them. We need comprehensive workman's compensation acts, both state and national laws to regulate child labor and work for women, and, especially, we need in our common schools not merely education in book-learning, but also practical training for daily life and work.

New Nationalism

The New Nationalism puts the national need before sectional or personal advantage. It is impatient of the utter confusion that results from local legislatures attempting to treat national issues as local issues. … This New Nationalism regards the executive power as the steward of the public welfare. It demands of the judiciary that it shall be interested primarily in human welfare rather than in property, just as it demands that the representative body shall represent all the people rather than any one class or section of the people.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	The Progressive Era; tension between Roosevelt's progressive wing and Taft's conservatives was splitting the Republican Party.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	A crowd of Kansas farmers and veterans at the John Brown memorial, plus the national press and progressive Republicans.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Theodore Roosevelt, a former Republican president who wanted to reclaim leadership of reform and expand federal power over business.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. LEQ Historical Reasoning — Comparison (1 pt): Write a thesis comparing TR's New Nationalism with Wilson's New Freedom in the 1912 election.
2. Identify ONE specific reform TR demands and ONE specific reform he does NOT (e.g., women's suffrage).
3. How does this speech anticipate the New Deal a generation later?